

From: motherofpekes@icloud.com
Subject: Re: Bitless Dressage Pilot Proposal and Request for Permission to Compete Bitless
Date: 28 March 2026 at 6:03 pm
To: Dressage Dressage@equestrian.org.au



Dear Caiwen,
Dear Members of the National Dressage Committee,

Thank you for your response confirming that participation in a bitless bridle cannot currently be approved under the EA Dressage Rules.

I appreciate that, at staff level, you are required to apply the rules as written. However, my correspondence is not simply a request for an individual exemption. It raises a broader welfare and policy issue that can only be addressed through review and amendment of the rules themselves.

I am therefore submitting this as a **formal member request for a rule change** to permit bitless bridles in EA dressage under defined conditions.

1. Request

I respectfully request that the National Dressage Committee:

1.1 Review the EA National Dressage Rules and Equipment Annex with the aim of permitting approved direct-action bitless bridles (e.g. sidepull and similar non-leverage designs).

1.2 Amend the rules so that:

- The definition of contact is hardware-neutral (light, elastic rein contact with the horse, assessed against the training scale, rather than “contact with the bit”); and
- The Equipment Annex includes a clearly defined category of permitted bitless bridles, with construction and fitting requirements to safeguard welfare.

1.3 Initiate a consultation process (e.g. draft rule change paper to members and officials) and publish the Committee’s position, including its welfare rationale.

2. Why a Rule Change Is Needed: Welfare

There is now substantial evidence that bits are not neutral tools but carry a significant welfare risk:

- Peer-reviewed veterinary studies document bit-related lesions and pathology, including soft tissue damage, bruising, and persistent oral discomfort.
- Biomechanical analyses indicate that rein forces commonly observed in normal riding fall within ranges that would be considered painful if applied to humans.
- Welfare bodies and scientific commentators increasingly identify bits — particularly in combination with tight nosebands or leverage — as potential sources of pain, distress, and abnormal behaviours.

In a discipline conducted primarily for human recreation, it is increasingly difficult to justify a rule that mandates an intra-oral device with this risk profile when viable, less invasive alternatives exist.

3. International Precedent

Other federations have already begun to modernise:

- The Dutch federation (KNHS) permits dressage competition in bitless bridles up to ZZ-Zwaar, with HC participation at higher levels.
- Acceptable designs are clearly defined (direct-action bridles with reins attached to a suitably wide noseband), with minimum specifications for welfare.
- Contact is judged in hardware-neutral terms.

This demonstrates that:

- Dressage can be judged consistently without requiring a bit;
- Bitless tack can be regulated through clear criteria; and
- The essence of dressage is not dependent on a specific piece of equipment.

Notably, EA already permits bitless bridles in other disciplines such as jumping and eventing, where safety demands are objectively higher.

4. Social Licence and Welfare Commitments

EA and the FEI have both committed publicly to prioritising horse welfare and maintaining social licence.

In that context, the continued requirement for an intra-oral device in a non-essential sporting activity is increasingly difficult to justify, particularly when:

- There is established evidence of bit-related pain and pathology;
- Bitless alternatives are already used successfully in training and competition;
- Emerging research suggests equal or improved welfare indicators without loss of control.

Allowing riders a choice — bitted or approved bitless — would align EA dressage with contemporary welfare expectations without mandating change for those who prefer traditional equipment.

5. Process Requested

I respectfully request that:

1. This correspondence, together with my previous emails (19 and 23 February, 6 March), be formally tabled with the National Dressage Committee and recorded as a rule change and welfare item.
2. The Committee consider drafting amendments to:
 - The definition of contact;
 - Permitted tack provisions; and
 - The Equipment Annex (to include direct action bitless bridles)

- The Equipment Annex (to include direct-action bitless bridles).
 - 3. The Committee provide a substantive written response addressing:
 - Whether it accepts that bits present a welfare risk;
 - Whether it is willing in principle to permit bitless bridles; and
 - If not, the reasons for maintaining a compulsory intra-oral device in light of current evidence and international precedent.
-

I would be pleased to assist by providing references, draft wording, or participating in any consultation process.

I would also appreciate confirmation that this request has been placed before the National Dressage Committee, and an indication of the expected timeline for discussion and response.

Kind regards,
Paula Lasersohn

#1050127

From: Dressage <Dressage@equestrian.org.au>
Sent: Tuesday, March 10, 2026 1:02 PM
To: motherofpekes@icloud.com <motherofpekes@icloud.com>
Subject: RE: Bitless Dressage Pilot Proposal and Request for Permission to Compete Bitless

Dear Paula,

I'm replying about your request below for an exemption to ride bitless; approval cannot be provided for participation in a bitless bridle at EA Dressage competitions even as HC, as it is currently not allowed in the EA Dressage rules.

Thank you,

Kind regards,

Caiwen

Caiwen Cusworth

**Sport Development Officer
Equestrian Australia**

+61 2 8762 7711 | Mailing address: PO Box 673 SYDNEY MARKETS NSW 2129 AUSTRALIA

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From: motherofpekes@icloud.com <motherofpekes@icloud.com>

Sent: Friday, 6 March 2026 4:39 PM

To: Dressage NSW Inc <admin@dressagensw.com.au>; Vireena Peacock <vireena@ensw.org.au>; Dressage <Dressage@equestrian.org.au>; Equestrian Info <info@equestrian.org.au>; NCEC Event Secretary <ncecevents@gmail.com>

Subject: Bitless Dressage Pilot Proposal and Request for Permission to Compete Bitless

Dear Equestrian Australia, Equestrian NSW, and NCEC Dressage,

Further to my previous correspondence regarding the possibility of introducing a pilot project to allow bitless bridles in dressage competition, I would like to provide additional information that may assist in your consideration of this proposal.

I have recently reviewed the national dressage regulations of the KNHS, the governing body for equestrian sport in the Netherlands. Their national rules specifically allow dressage tests to be ridden in approved bitless bridles up to ZZ-Zwaar level (approximately equivalent to Small Tour preparation).

The relevant sections of the Dutch national dressage regulations for your reference. The full rules can be found here:

<https://www.knhs.nl/reglementen/disciplinereglement-dressuur>

The relevant section is Article 147, which reads:

“Dressage tests may be ridden bitless up to the ZZ-Zwaar level for both horses and ponies. From the Light Tour level onwards, participation bitless is only permitted hors concours (HC).

The following bitless bridles are permitted (see the KNHS Harness Guide):

- The sidepull
- The chin-crossed bitless bridle
- The cheek-crossed bitless bridle
- Other permitted bitless bridles with the reins attached directly to the noseband

The bridle must be made of leather with a noseband at least 2 cm wide. There may be no metal core in the noseband. When using a chin-crossed or cheek-crossed bridle, if cords are used they must have a minimum diameter of 6 mm.

The description of the individual dressage tests and associated explanations

contained in Appendix 6 apply, with the exception that in dressage tests ridden bitless, 'contact' as described in the training scale means light contact on the reins with the horse and the horse's head and neck position."

Of particular interest is the way the Dutch rules define contact when riding bitless. Rather than referring to contact with a bit, the rules define contact as light rein contact with the horse, while judges continue to assess the same qualities of training and performance. In other words, judging remains based on the training scale and the horse's way of going, rather than the hardware used.

This approach allows bitless participation without altering the fundamental principles of dressage judging, and may therefore provide a useful precedent when considering how bitless riding could be incorporated within existing dressage structures in Australia.

As previously mentioned, I would be very interested in supporting a small pilot project or demonstration class to explore how this might work within the Australian context.

In the meantime, I would also like to respectfully request permission to ride in a bitless bridle at the upcoming NCEC dressage competition for which entries are currently open. I would of course be happy to compete hors concours (HC) if that would make participation easier within the existing rules.

My intention is simply to demonstrate that a horse trained according to the scales of training can be presented successfully in a bitless bridle while still meeting the same standards expected in dressage competition.

Thank you very much for your time and consideration. I would be grateful for any guidance you may be able to provide.

Kind regards,
Paula Lasersohn